Thomas Yu

Teaching Statement

I teach economics as a way of reasoning rather than a body of facts. Students should leave my classroom able to confidently build an argument from assumptions to conclusions, to question those assumptions and connect economics to their own lives, and to feel comfortable making mistakes on the way to understanding. Those habits – clear reasoning, critical thinking, and the willingness to take intellectual risks – are what I aim to develop in every course I teach.

Teaching experience. I have been a teaching assistant at Yale for five semesters in three undergraduate microeconomics courses: Introductory Microeconomics (Spring 2024 and Fall 2024), Intermediate Microeconomics (Fall 2023 and Spring 2025), and Game Theory (Fall 2025). In each, I led weekly discussion sections, held office hours, and ran final exam reviews. I also completed Yale's Certificate of College Teaching Preparation: nine teaching workshops, two learning communities on grading and inclusive classrooms, and four classroom observations.

How I teach. Students arrive with different backgrounds, so every class starts with a roadmap, and every concept with intuition before notation. Once a model is on the board, I ask students where they have seen it in the real world; when a student connected rising marginal cost with the crowded counter at his bakery, the whole room got it. That exchange only happens if students are willing to speak up, so I allow for long pauses and follow up with anyone still unsure. I am always looking for ways to improve: when observers noted that I sometimes answered before finding the source of confusion, I began asking students to restate ideas in their own words. My sections became more interactive, and students grew more willing to voice uncertainty and work together.

I design much of my own teaching material. My solution guides explain why each step is needed, pair every derivation with intuition and visuals, and offer more than one route to each answer so every student can find one that works. For exam reviews, I prepare slides that summarize the course and then solve example problems live, so students see how a solution is built.

In teaching evaluations, one student wrote that I was "easily one of the strongest parts of this course" and that my "weekly sections were far more helpful than the lectures." Another wrote that I "would keep explaining the idea until I really grasped the concept" and added, "If there's a TF/TA award or prize, I nominate him for it!" A student from my first section later wrote to me, unprompted, to thank me for my "patient and kind teaching style" and "a great experience in my first economics class." A teaching consultant who observed my section wrote that students were "very comfortable speaking up and asking questions, even questions they thought might be silly."

What I can teach. I am prepared to teach a wide range of courses – including health economics and policy, industrial organization, econometrics and applied methods, and microeconomic theory – at any level, undergraduate or graduate. I also welcome advising students at all levels in these and related areas. I am especially excited to teach two courses I have designed in full. The first, an introductory applied microeconomics course, replaces lectures with discussion, case studies, and weekly data labs with real datasets, and ends with a policy memo that students may revise and resubmit. The second, an advanced health economics seminar, centers on student-led policy seminars, explorations of health data, and a research proposal.